

WILL SMITH SILVERSTONE AUCTION SE DIT

My great pleasure this week is to have as my guest Will Smith, the sales manager of Silverstone Auctions in Warwickshire in the UK, and Will, welcome to the program. Hi, thanks very much for having me. We're standing in front of Eric Morecambe's fabulous Jensen Interceptor vehicle, and I can't believe it's the real thing.

Yeah, it was his car, he bought it new, it's got a few stories attached with it, but we've restored it ourselves and it looks beautiful in front of us. What was it like when you got hold of it? It was in a fairly sort of original condition, but sort of had been neglected for probably 10, 15 years, so we decided to bring it back to life. And tell us a story, where was it found and how did that come about? Sure, it was bought by our boss, who was a huge, massive fan of Eric Morecambe's, and he found it through a local West Midlands contact that he'd had, and knew of the car for many years, but it took time for him to actually buy it. Was it one of those stories where it was hanging around in a barn somewhere, or just off the road, and something like that? I think a sort of garage type situation was where it was stored, it was looked after by an old chap who'd had it for many years, and really couldn't really afford to maintain it, as it was becoming in need of restoration and recommissioning.

Now, what was the process once you got hold of it, and I suppose you do this with all your vehicles, you take it back to bare metal and start again? Yeah, we basically strip the entire car of all of its components to a complete bare shell, and rub that down until we get to bare metal, primer it and paint it, and that whole process took probably about a year and a half. Just for this vehicle? Absolutely, yeah, so it's a very long-term proposition to restore one of these cars. Well, such an iconic vehicle, and there's some great stories about it, can you tell us a couple of those? Yeah, Mr Morecambe was driving it one day, and something felt a bit strange, and it turned out he was having a heart attack, so he pulled over to the side of the road and explained to a passing stranger that he was having a heart attack, and that he required medical assistance, so the stranger jumped in the Jensen and took him to the hospital, where Mr Morecambe was treated for his heart attack.

And it was quite funny, because I believe the fellow was a Yorkshireman who said his mates wouldn't believe him, that it was actually, you know, Eric Morecambe. Yeah, well he was a huge part of British institution, almost, in the 70s, 80s, and to that generation, you know, he's a very special guy. And this is a very special car, tell us a bit about the car itself, and the history of the Jensen background.

Well, the Jensen Inceptor was actually a very advanced car for its day, and it employed four-wheel-drive technology later in the FF version, and, you know, really it was seen as quite a pioneering English, hand-built, very expensive when it was brand new, piece of British motoring, which, you know, took some influences from America in the sense that it was a V8, it was a General Motors V8 that was in the front, that combined with British styling, and, you know, the

bodywork is absolutely beautiful to look at today. And what would the cost of this be, this Jensen Inceptor, in today's value? If you wanted to buy it, say, I suppose in the late 60s or whatever, when it was around, what would you have to fork out today for it? Today, it would be in the region of anywhere from £50,000 to £150,000, depending on the car, the condition, the provenance, etc. This car obviously, you know, is towards the upper echelons of that price spectrum, but that's because of its history, it's unique, and it's been beautifully restored.

And I suppose if this went to auction with you guys, the sky's the limit, really, isn't it, if someone really wanted it? Absolutely, all you need is two people who love Eric Morecambe, and the car could go for serious money. So, at the moment, we're just enjoying it, we like displaying it, and it's a lovely thing to have on our stand. And Will Smith, the sales manager at Silverstone Auctions in the UK, how can people find out more about your company? Basically, all they need to do is go to silverstoneauctions.com, and they can see our upcoming auctions, who we are, what we do, and get a flavour for our company and how we approach things.

Great, Will Smith, thank you very much for being part of the program this week. Very welcome, thank you.